STATE SCAN

KERALA: THEATRE OF WAR *PG 20*

GUJARAT: GLASS HALF FULL, HALF CLOUDY *PG 22*



AFP

REDEEMED Kejriwal returns to a rousing welcome at the AAP headquarters after his acquittal, Feb. 27, Delhi

▶ DELHI

CLEAN CHIT FOR THE AAM AADMI

A Delhi court's dismissal of the 'Liquorgate' charges gives AAP and Arvind Kejriwal much-needed validation to woo back voters

By **Avishek G. Dastidar**

THERE IS A KIND OF THEATRE THAT INDIAN POLITICS DOES BETTER than even the movies and sports—the impossible comeback. On February 27, a Delhi court wrote the possible opening scenes of one such when it demolished the 'Liquorgate' chargesheet penned by the Central Bureau of Investigation. It was a collective exoneration—of practically the entire Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government that was deposed in Delhi a year ago on the back of a diminished aura. But the spotlight also narrowed on a singular figure, an icon obscured by clouds: Arvind Kejriwal.

Acquitting the former chief minister and the rest—deputy CM Manish Sisodia and 21 others—special judge Jitendra Singh reserved no judgement while upbraiding the probe agencies: "The investigation appears to have proceeded on a predetermined trajectory, implicating virtually everyone associated with the formulation or implementation of the policy in order to lend an illusion of depth and credibility to an otherwise fragile narrative."